

HARD DRIVES

In the past year, nothing significant has happened in this category in terms of the technology; the trend of prices dropping did continue, though. Then, IDE drives went out, to be completely replaced by the faster SATA interface. Perpendicular recording, introduced last year, is becoming mainstream—320 GB drives built upon this technology are priced really well. We expect things to stay the way they are for at least a couple of years, before Flash-based hard drives start the process of phasing out magnetic storage media—but that remains to be seen. Also, some drives that cater to AV specialists have been unveiled along with so-called “green” hard drives that claim to consume lower power—we shall see a lot of this next year.

Things were similar with external drives. The interface has remained the same—USB, and FireWire, while capacities have increased. In this case as well, drives based on perpendicular recording are increasingly being used, especially in the backup category. Micro hard drive based external drives were nowhere to be seen, and this indicates the waning interest in that category, which was last featured in 2006. In the coming year, we expect to see drives featuring the new eSATA interface sporting 3 Gbps speeds and thus, great performance. Networking is in vogue, we therefore expect that more and more of the drives will feature an interface such as RJ-45 or even Wi-Fi, because such drives don't need a PC to be able to serve as a file server.

INTERNAL SATA

The Reigning Champion Western Digital Caviar SE16 WD3200AAKS

This 7200 rpm drive hits the sweet spot for internal hard drives, with a generous capacity of 320 GB and excellent performance, along with a superb pause per MB of just 1.47. Sporting the SATA II interface, it has a large 16 MB buffer—great especially when you're transferring large files of loading large game levels.

The Contender Western Digital Caviar SE16 WD5000AAKS

This drive differs from the Reigning



Champion only in terms of capacity; the performance is very similar, but it loses out on the price front: it costs Rs 7,500, placing it a little off the sweet spot.

The Award Western Digital Caviar SE16 WD3200AAKS

The Western Digital Caviar SE16 WD3200AAKS excelled in all our tests, synthetic and real-world. It posted an excellent 66.8 MBps and 64.5 MBps in the read and write tests in HDTach, with a low CPU usage of just 2 per cent and a low random access time of 12.7 ms. It scored 154 MBps in H2Bench—again a good score. It was the top scorer in PCMark 05. The drive also scores well in real-



world file transfers—less than a minute to copy a 4 GB file to and from the drive, while transferring it between partitions on the drive took just over 2.5 minutes. Priced at a really affordable Rs 4,500, this drive gets the Zero1 award in this category.

BACKUP EXTERNAL HARD DRIVES

The Reigning Champion Western Digital My Book Essential

The Western Digital My Book Essential looks like a reference book, and sports a rugged build. This 500 GB drive has 16 MB of buffer. The design allows you to stack drives one on top of the other to increase capacity. It weighs 1.32 kg, meaning it's easy to carry around.

The Contender Maxtor OneTouch III Turbo Edition

This 1 TB drive is built very well, and has a backup button that works in conjunction with the excellent EMC Retrospect software (bun-



dled). The drive supports the speedy FireWire 800 interface in addition to USB 2.0. This was the fastest performer in this category, but is priced at Rs 36,200—which goes against it if you're looking for a winner.

The Award Western Digital My Book Essential

Our Zero1 award winner in this category, the Western Digital My Book Essential top-scored in almost every test we threw at it. The average read speed is 34.2 MBps, while write speed is 23.9 MBps. It took just 40 seconds to write a 1 GB file to the drive, while reading it from



the drive took an amazingly low 35 seconds. Copying 1 GB of assorted data to and fro takes just 1.5 minutes, which means it's one of the fastest drives. It comes with a USB 2.0 data cable as well as a power adapter. The bundled WD Diagnostics utility helps you troubleshoot any problems you might encounter. The price is just Rs 8,300.

PORTABLE EXTERNAL HARD DRIVES

The Reigning Champion Western Digital Passport Portable (Black)

This drive is just a little bigger than a passport, and it is quite light at 231 grams. The body is of a strong black polymer with a piano black finish on the top and a rubberised finish at the bottom that provides the grip needed to prevent sliding off a surface. The 8 MB buffer is sufficient for sustained data transfers over USB 2.0.

The Contender Iomega Portable Hard Drive

This 80 GB Iomega drive is very sleek, and was the lightest drive in this category. The casing has an extra power socket for when the drive is unable to draw enough from the USB connec-



tor. Though it is just a 4200 rpm drive, we found the performance commendable—almost as good as that of the reigning champion. It comes with EMC Retrospect to take care of your backup needs. The pricing is very sensible.

The Award Western Digital Passport Portable (Black)

This drive has a read speed of 33 MBps, while the write speed is 23 MB/s. Writing a 1 GB file to the drive takes just 42 seconds, while reading it back is even faster at 36 seconds; This makes it a top scorer in this category,



but in addition, its performance is comparable even to that of some of the faster backup external drives. WD provides a USB 2.0 cable. The bundled WD Sync software is good for all kinds of backup, meaning you won't have to spend extra on a third-party application. The price is good, too—Rs 6,500.